On 'Election Duty'

Elections are between the neta and the public. But our bureaucracy is a bit like divinity: even if not omnipotent, it's surely omnipresent. How do you then keep the good officers, with their keen sense of duty, out of a general election? Three vignettes frame the dubious proximity of politics and babudom, directly or obliquely. Andhra Pradesh BJP chief Daggubati Purandeswari has petitioned the EC asking for chief secretary K.S. Jawahar Reddy and DGP K.V. Rajendranath Reddy to be replaced. Reason: 'bias' towards CM Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy. The EC is listening with intent. Up in Telangana, P. Venkatrami Reddy, BRS candidate from Medak, was kicking up a hullabaloo of his own. Now, 'PVR' is a former district collector from Siddipet, the constituency HQ. So it wasn't too difficult for him to summon his old troops—obedient government employees all—for a meeting. But Congress and BJP leaders, tipped off in time, reached the venue, had it sealed and called in the cops. Some 106 sarkari staff have been suspended till early June, till counting is done. Further north, in Bhopal, MP, an officer is walking back to the pavilion after a witless political inning. Nisha Bangre, a state administrative service officer who had resigned to join the Congress ahead of the December assembly election (eyeing a ticket), now wants her job back. Bangre has written to the state government saying she had acted in haste—the gentle rhythms of life as sub-divisional magistrate were evidently much better than the snake pit of electoral politics. ■





too much of a good thing, he balanced things out on Baisakhi day, performing the shabad kirtan at a local gurudwara. All of this is organic enough for Hans Raj Hans, who in his heyday had been Punjab's topmost Sufi singer. How auspicious will all this prove? Well, Punjab isn't exactly ready to be harvested by the BJP. The dominant Jat Sikhs harbour plenty residual anger against the BJP from the farm protest days. Nor are they known for gulping down Hindutva. Faridkot, in fact, is a hotbed of panthic politics—in 2015, the bulk of sacrilege incidents happened here. The BJP last contested this seat in 1991, when their candidate Raj Kumar Girdhar lost his deposit with a mere 6.7 per cent votes. Hans got a reminder of that when his convoy was shown black flags by farm unions. But he responded by showering petals on them. Whatever they might do elsewhere, Faridkot, too, has a small *mohabbat ki dukaan*. Now to wait for customers. ■

Shifting House?



Not many may recall that Karnataka's ex-CM **H.D. Kumaraswamy** started legislative life as a Lok Sabha MP, in 1996, when his dad Deve Gowda was PM. Mandya is his chosen arena for a third stint as MP. But in this Battle of the Vokkaligas, the JD(S) chief is up against INDIA's rookie richie rich 'Star Chandru'.



Another ex-CM, another son of a politico who took the flavours of Karnataka to New Delhi. The late Janata leader S.R. Bommai's memory is now mostly restricted to the SC's eponymous 'Bommai judgment'. Now **Basavaraj Bommai** has a chance to mull over Centre-state relations from the other side—if he makes it from Haveri for the BJP.



Jagadish Shettar is a dyed-in-the-wool saffronite, born to an old Jan Sanghi family from Bagalkote, up north. A less-than-memorable go at party-hopping politics has ended: he has pivoted back from the Congress, with his Lingayat base presumably intact. The third ex-Karnataka CM is in the fray for the BJP from Belgaum. As with Bommai, an LS debut beckons.

Rohit Parihar, Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Jeemon Jacob, Amarnath K. Menon, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Amitabh Srivastava, Anilesh S. Mahajan, Ajay Sukumaran and Rahul Noronha